

The Lost Son



SCRIPTURE · Luke 15:11–31

The Lost Son · ESV

MAIN MESSAGE

God's mercy and grace toward lost sinners is extravagant, undeserved, and even scandalous. Through the two sons, Jesus reveals that there are two ways to be lost and far from the Father—by running away in open sin like the younger son, or by staying home and trying to earn God's favor like the older son. Yet both must be rescued by the same astounding grace. God's lavish compassion welcomes both sons home through grace and repentant faith.

DISCOVERY QUESTIONS

- 01 Where are you most tempted to relate to God based on performance instead of relationship?
- 02 Do you tend to run from God or try to prove yourself to Him? Why?

Discovering Truth

The tension in this parable comes from who Jesus is addressing. He's speaking to religious men who believed closeness to God was earned through discipline, behavior, and separation from those who didn't measure up. They were frustrated that Jesus welcomed sinners because it challenged their system. In their minds, proximity to God was achieved. Jesus confronts that directly—not with an argument, but with a story that reveals a different reality: proximity to God is received, not earned.

01 · PARABLE ONE

The Younger Son

The Younger Son represents open rebellion. He demands what he believes belongs to him, walks away from the father, and builds a life on his own terms. At first, it looks like freedom—no authority, no limits, no accountability—but that version of freedom doesn't last. It leads to emptiness, desperation, and collapse. When he hits bottom, he decides to return, but even then, his thinking is off. Yet before he can even finish his apology, the father runs to him—restoring his son without condition. This is grace.

02 · PARABLE TWO

The Older Son

The Older Son represents a different kind of lostness. He never leaves physically, and from the outside, his life looks right. But when grace is extended to his brother, what is underneath is exposed. He is angry, not because something wrong happened, but because something unearned was given. His relationship with the father was never rooted in love—it was transactional. His obedience was an attempt to earn righteousness.

03 · THE FATHER

The Father

This parable exposes two different spiritual conditions of men. A man can rebel openly like the younger son or perform quietly like the older son, and both paths can leave him equally distant from God. One builds life on independence. The other builds life on effort.

And yet, the father moves toward both. He runs to the younger son and goes out to plead with the older son. He does not wait for either of them to fix themselves—he initiates restoration. Through Jesus, God moves toward men, absorbing the cost Himself to bring them back into relationship—not as servants trying to prove their worth, but as sons who receive it.

Key Points

01

Closeness to God is not earned through rebellion or performance—it is received through grace.

02

You can be far from God through open sin or through outward obedience rooted in a transactional mindset.

03

The Father's response reveals His compassion, kindness, and lavish grace—He runs toward those who recognize their need, repent, and come home.

04

The Father moves toward you first, and you are not home until you stop proving yourself and receive what He freely gives.

GROUP DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 01 Where are you chasing freedom outside of God right now, and what has that pursuit produced in your life?
- 02 Why do people try to earn their way back instead of receiving and accepting His grace?
- 03 Do you ever feel like God owes you something because of your effort?
- 04 How do you respond when others receive grace you don't think they deserve?
- 05 Which son do you relate to more right now—and why?
- 06 What is keeping you from fully coming home to God?

Personal Reflection

Most men live in one of two lanes with God—you either run or you perform. Both miss the point. You don't earn your way back to God, and you don't outperform your need for Him. Real strength is not proving yourself—it's surrendering. The moment you stop running and start receiving grace is the moment your life actually begins to change.

PERSONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- 01 Where are you currently trying to prove your worth instead of receiving it from God?
- 02 What is one area of your life where you've been running instead of returning?
- 03 Where does pride or quiet judgment show up in your life like the older son?
- 04 In your environment (team, work, family), how can you lead with grace this week?
- 05 What is one clear step you will take this week to move toward God?